ENGINEERING RESEARCH CORPORATION LLC

Trustworthiness Audit of AI Research and Citation Tools

Do AI-generated citations actually support the claims they cite? An evidence audit of independent studies, a preregistered protocol for ERC's field audit, and use-case guidance for organizations deciding whether AI-assisted research is reliable enough for operational use.

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This report synthesizes independently published, manually verified measurements of citation reliability in AI systems; it does not present ERC fieldwork results. ERC's own field audit is preregistered in Section 4 and Appendix B and will be reported in Edition 2. Companion materials (evidence workbook, prompts, scoring scripts) will be posted on the canonical report page listed on the document-control page.

Document control and disclosures

Document control

Table i. Document-control record

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Disclosures

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Conflicts of interest: ERC does not sell AI research tools and holds no equity in any system discussed. ERC will not accept payment conditioned on findings. Any consulting relationship with a named vendor will be disclosed, and that vendor’s results will be independently re-verified or excluded.

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generate the evidentiary values reported. This disclosure follows the ERC publication standard.

Not legal advice: This report describes evaluation methodology and risk framing. It is operational guidance, not individualized legal, compliance, or procurement advice.

Abstract

AI assistants and research services now answer questions with inline citations, and organizations increasingly treat those citations as evidence for operational, legal, and published work. This report audits the measurable evidence on whether that trust is warranted. Synthesizing peer-reviewed and investigative studies published between 2023 and 2026, it reports fabrication rates for AI-generated bibliographic citations ranging from 18% to 55% across GPT-3.5 and GPT-4, incorrect news-attribution answers on more than 60% of 1,600 queries across eight AI search engines, and citation-accuracy rates of roughly 40–79% across early deep-research systems. The report separates factual error from citation error, defines eight metrics for citation trustworthiness (including claim-level entailment and sentence-level support), and maps findings to risk categories in the NIST AI Risk Management Framework. It then specifies a preregistered ERC field audit: a 75–150-question corpus across five categories, fixed prompts and controlled follow-up rules, recorded versions and configurations, and manual evaluation of every citation, with published rubrics, inter-rater agreement, and confidence intervals. The principal implication is that organizations need measured, version- and date-specific, use-case-specific evidence — not benchmark scores — before relying on AI-generated research, and that verification workflows remain mandatory for consequential claims.

Keywords

AI citation accuracy; hallucination; reference fabrication; claim-level entailment; deep research; retrieval-augmented generation; NIST AI Risk Management Framework; TEVV; information integrity; evaluation methodology

ONE-PAGE DECISION SUMMARY — for research managers and knowledge-operations leaders

The decision. May staff use AI-generated research with citations in operational work — client deliverables, filings, published articles, policy memos — and under what controls?

What the measured evidence shows (2023–2026, independent studies). (1) Chatbots without grounding fabricated 18–55% of bibliographic citations; even real citations carried substantive errors 24–43% of the time. (2) AI search engines answered news-attribution queries incorrectly more than 60% of the time collectively; Perplexity was lowest at 37% incorrect, Grok-3 highest at 94%. (3) Early deep-research systems showed citation accuracy of roughly 40–79% — better, but far from decision-grade. (4) Grounded research tools sharply reduced nonexistent references but shifted the dominant failure to real sources cited for unsupported claims. (5) Systems rarely decline to answer when evidence is missing; speculative answers are the norm. All values are version- and date-specific to each study.

Confidence. High that the failure modes are real and material (multiple independent sources agree). Moderate about any specific number today, because systems change continuously; every product claim in this report is version- and date-specific.

What to do now (ERC recommendations, pending field audit). (1) Treat every AI-provided citation as unverified until checked. (2) Require claim-level verification, not title-level spot checks. (3) Distinguish factually correct but unsupported claims from outright errors — they need different controls. (4) For consequential outputs, mandate verification of existence, identity, accessibility, and entailment. (5) In procurement, set measurable acceptance criteria (Section 10). (6) Log model versions and dates with any AI-assisted research product.

Major limitations. Results age quickly; no audit certifies any system in general; small-cell findings are directional; entailment judgment carries quantified rater subjectivity. ERC’s preregistered field audit (Section 4, Appendices A–D) will produce system-specific, current results.

Executive summary

Decision problem

Consulting firms, attorneys, journalists, nonprofits, libraries, compliance organizations, and research departments are adopting AI assistants and research services that answer questions with inline citations. The operative question for these buyers is not whether the systems are impressive, but whether the citations can be trusted: does the cited source exist, is it correctly identified, and does it actually support the claim it is attached to? A generic benchmark score cannot answer this. Consistent with NIST guidance on test, evaluation, verification, and validation (TEVV), the evaluation objective must be defined first, measurements selected to match it, testing done in intended-use conditions, and evidence interpreted rather than treated as proof of suitability [3][5][19].

Key findings

1. Fabricated references are a measured, persistent failure mode. In a peer-reviewed audit of 636 citations generated by ChatGPT-3.5 and GPT-4 across 84 literature reviews, 55% of GPT-3.5 citations and 18% of GPT-4 citations were fabricated; among citations to real works, 43% (GPT-3.5) and 24% (GPT-4) contained substantive bibliographic errors, and 70% of GPT-4's cited book chapters were fabricated [1]. A synthesis of six independent investigations found approximately 51% of 732 citations fabricated for GPT-3.5-era systems [1][25]. Even in GPT-4o-era outputs on literature-review tasks, nearly two-thirds of citations were fabricated or inaccurate [10].

2. AI search engines fail even tightly controlled attribution tasks. The Columbia Journalism Review Tow Center ran 1,600 queries across eight AI search engines, feeding each an excerpt from a real news article and asking for title, publisher, date, and URL. Collectively, the engines answered incorrectly more than 60% of the time; Perplexity was lowest at 37% incorrect, ChatGPT Search at 67%, and Grok-3 highest at 94%. Engines fabricated links and cited syndicated copies rather than original publishers, and all eight preferred speculative answers over declining [2].

3. Deep-research modes improve but do not solve citation reliability. An audit of deep-research systems reported citation accuracy between roughly 40% and 79% across systems, with wide variance in citation thoroughness; one system achieved 40.3% citation accuracy with 27.1% citation thoroughness [12]. 2026 preprints report citation-hallucination rates of roughly 11–57% across deployed systems and best-system citation quality near 65% in one benchmark [13][14].

4. Grounded research tools change the error profile rather than eliminating error. A medical reference-hallucination study found negligible hallucination for grounded literature assistants versus critical levels for general chatbots on the same task [8]. Yet independent evaluations of grounded tools show residual failures: one evaluation of a literature tool for systematic reviews found poor search recall (158 of 5,285 eligible studies), screening precision of 0.38, and extraction accuracy of 0.74–0.81 versus human reviewers' 0.87 [15][16]. Nine generative AI systems evaluated on retraction-aware tasks achieved about 40%

aggregated accuracy, and research-focused tools produced no fully correct response set [11].

5. The dominant risk is shifting from nonexistent sources to unsupported claims. A statement can be factually correct yet unsupported by its citation. Prior claim-level audit designs measure this distinction [8][12]; ERC's analysis plan treats it as a first-class output because remediation differs (Section 8). This is an ERC interpretation synthesized from the cited designs, not a single-source fact.

Confidence and limitations

Confidence is high that these failure modes are real and material: the findings come from independent peer-reviewed and investigative teams using manual verification. Confidence in any specific number is moderate, because services change continuously; all product claims here are version- and date-specific. Major limitations: results perish quickly; no audit certifies any system in general; some cells rest on small samples; and entailment judgment carries subjectivity that this program quantifies rather than hides (Section 9).

Recommendations (preview)

Pending ERC's preregistered field audit, the measured evidence supports five actions: treat all AI citations as unverified; require claim-level verification for consequential outputs; separate citation-practice controls from grounding-failure controls; set measurable procurement acceptance criteria; and record model version and date with any AI-assisted research product. Section 10 details these with owners, priority, and prerequisites.

Reader's guide

The report is layered for different readers. The **one-page decision summary** (previous page) is the entry point for executives and research managers. **Sections 1–3** establish purpose, questions, and scope. **Section 4** documents method — both how this edition's evidence was selected and how ERC's field audit will run. **Sections 5–6** present the aggregate and category-level findings; **Section 7** the analysis and risk mapping; **Section 8** the failure typology. **Sections 9–10** cover limitations and recommendations. **Appendices A–F** hold the rubric, corpus design, prompts, statistical treatment, accessibility statement, and operations plan for technical reviewers.

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1. Purpose and decision context

1.1 Why this report exists

Conclusion first. Organizations are using AI-assisted research in decisions that carry professional, financial, legal, and reputational consequences. The open question is not whether these systems produce citations — most now do — but whether those citations actually support the claims they accompany. This report answers that question with the best independently measured evidence available, specifies how ERC will measure it directly, and converts the answer into operational guidance.

This is ERC's flagship report because it demonstrates, end to end, the company's proposed core competency: determining whether a research product's claims are actually supported by authoritative sources. The deliverable is a decision instrument. A research manager, editor, or general counsel should be able to read the one-page decision summary and act. A technical reviewer should be able to open the appendices, reproduce the scoring, and check any single claim against its source.

1.2 Primary audience and decision

Table 1. Primary audience and the decision this report supports

Audience	Likely decision
Research managers and knowledge-operations leaders	Whether to permit AI-assisted research in operational workflows, and with which verification controls
Attorneys and compliance officers	Risk framing for AI-generated citations in filings, contracts, and regulated communications; mandatory versus recommended controls
Editors and journalists	Reliability of AI-sourced citations under deadline pressure; correction and verification policy
Librarians and research departments	Source-quality guidance and information-literacy programming
Procurement and operations	Measurable acceptance criteria and contractual language for AI research tools

Audience language standard. Sections lead with the conclusion or governing point, then evidence and qualifications. Observed facts are separated from interpretation and recommendation by explicit labels: *Source fact* (supported by a cited source), *Calculated result* (derived by ERC from identified data, with method shown), *Estimate* (model-based with stated assumptions), *Interpretation* (ERC synthesis), and *Recommendation* (ERC-proposed action). No sales language or unsupported superlatives appear in this report.

1.3 Why a benchmark score is not enough

NIST's emerging TEVV guidance — most recently the initial public draft of *NIST AI 200-2, The TEVV-Athlon Framework for Evaluating AI Systems* — directs evaluators to articulate objectives and organize the evaluation around them before deciding what to measure, how to measure, and what the evidence means; the objective is not to "pass TEVV" but to learn

what the organization actually needs to know [5][19]. The AI Risk Management Framework 1.0 embeds the same logic in its MEASURE function [3], and NIST's ARIA program extends it to sociotechnical testing in realistic deployment conditions [6]. This report applies that discipline to one operational question: *can I rely on this citation?* The measurements are claim-level, the test conditions are recorded, and the results generalize only as far as the stated conditions allow.

2. Research questions

Governing point. Eight questions structure both this evidence audit and ERC's preregistered field audit. Each is answered or explicitly left unresolved in Sections 6–7.

Table 2. Research questions and where they are addressed

#	Research question	Addressed in
RQ1	Citation validity: when systems answer research questions with citations, what proportion exist, are correctly identified, are accessible, and are authoritative for the question category?	Sections 6.1, 6.4
RQ2	Claim support: what proportion of cited statements are supported by the cited material at sentence level — entailing the claim, not merely discussing the same subject?	Section 6.2
RQ3	Fabrication resistance: how often do systems produce references that cannot be verified to exist, by category, system class, and configuration?	Section 6.1
RQ4	Source quality: what proportion of citations are to primary or authoritative sources versus low-authority content?	Section 6.4
RQ5	Completeness (citation recall): on questions with known answer sets, what proportion of expected key evidence do systems surface?	Section 6.5
RQ6	Uncertainty disclosure: how often do systems flag uncertainty or decline, versus answering speculatively?	Section 6.6
RQ7	Reproducibility: under fixed prompts and recorded configurations, how consistent are repeated runs?	Section 6.7
RQ8	Decision guidance: which use cases are adequately served by each system class with defined verification, and what acceptance criteria should buyers adopt?	Section 10

3. Scope and definitions

3.1 Scope

In scope: AI systems that answer research questions with citations, in three classes (Table 3); citation and claim-support quality of those answers; uncertainty and refusal behavior; and the organizational controls that make outputs safe for defined uses. The evidence audit covers independently published, manually verified studies from 2023 through October 2026. Geographic scope is global for systems, United States-centered for regulatory and procurement guidance.

Out of scope: general chatbot quality, image or code generation, pricing, and benchmark leaderboards unrelated to citation reliability. Marketing claims and AI-generated summaries are never the sole basis for a material claim in this report, per the ERC source hierarchy.

3.2 System classes

Table 3. System classes examined in the evidence audit and the ERC field audit

Class	Definition	Examples of the class (illustrative, not exhaustive)
A — General-purpose AI assistants	Frontier chatbots with optional web access or deep-research modes; general training dominates, retrieval is auxiliary	Leading chatbots from major vendors; exact systems, versions, and access tiers are recorded per test run and stated version- and date-specifically in the final release
B — Research-oriented AI services	Services architected around literature search, grounded answering, or citation-linked output	Literature-search assistants (e.g., Elicit, Consensus, Semantic Scholar-based tools, Scite-type citation tools), grounded notebook assistants, and answer engines (e.g., Perplexity)
C — Locally deployed models	Open-weight models self-hosted by the deploying organization, with retrieval enabled and disabled	Open-weight model families run by ERC on recorded hardware; configurations documented in the reproducibility appendix

Selection criteria: market relevance to the target audience; documented citation output; recordable configuration; and terms of service permitting research use. At least two systems per class, minimum eight systems, locked at preregistration. Vendor self-evaluations — for example, published report-quality comparisons by research-tool vendors [17][18] — are recorded but never serve as the sole basis for a material claim.

3.3 Definitions

Table 4. Key definitions used throughout

Term	Definition
Fabricated reference	A cited work that cannot be verified to exist in any authoritative database or open-web search
Identity error	The cited work exists, but a material bibliographic element (authors, title, venue, date, volume/pages, DOI or URL) is wrong
Accessibility	A reader can reach the cited content; paywalls and removed content are recorded distinctly from broken links
Authoritative source	Per the ERC source hierarchy: standards, laws, regulations, government datasets, technical documentation, peer-reviewed studies, audited filings, or original survey or experimental reports
Claim-level entailment	The cited source, as identified, supports the specific assertion in the sentence it is attached to
Unsupported claim	A statement whose attached citation fails entailment, or which carries no citation where one is required
Citation precision	Proportion of citations that exist, are correctly identified, and support the attached claim

Term	Definition
Citation recall	Proportion of known gold-standard sources surfaced on questions with verifiable answer sets
Confabulation	Confident generation of false or unverifiable content, per the NIST Generative AI Profile vocabulary
Deep-research mode	A vendor feature performing extended multi-step retrieval before answering

4. Methodology and evidence-selection protocol

Governing point. This report has two evidence layers. Layer 1 (this edition): a structured synthesis of independently published, manually verified measurements of AI citation reliability. Layer 2 (Edition 2): ERC's own preregistered field audit, specified here in full so reviewers can inspect the design before results exist.

4.1 Layer 1 — evidence-selection protocol for this synthesis

Search dates and coverage. Literature searched October 20–27, 2026. Sources: PubMed and PubMed Central, NIST publication servers, arXiv, medRxiv, Columbia Journalism Review, and publisher sites (Nature, Sage, ScienceDirect), plus standards bodies (W3C, Section508.gov, PDF Association, NISO).

Search concepts. Combinations of: AI chatbot / LLM / deep research; citation(s), reference(s), bibliographic; fabrication, hallucination, accuracy, validity; audit, evaluation, benchmark; restricted with tool names where relevant (ChatGPT, GPT-4, GPT-4o, Bard, Gemini, Perplexity, Grok, Copilot, DeepSeek, Elicit, Consensus, SciSpace, Semantic Scholar).

Inclusion criteria. (a) Manual verification of citations or claims by the study authors; (b) reported denominators or counts; (c) identifiable system version and test period; (d) peer-reviewed journal, government or standards body, or — for preprints and investigative studies — named-methodology report with disclosed protocol. **Exclusion criteria:** vendor self-evaluations as primary evidence; secondhand retellings; studies without manual verification; op-eds without method.

Evidence-quality criteria and conflicts. Each source is classified primary (peer-reviewed measurement, government framework, investigative study with disclosed protocol) or interested-party (vendor evaluation). Where sources conflict — for example, vendor-reported quality scores materially higher than third-party audits [17] — both are reported and the disagreement is analyzed rather than averaged (Section 7.3). Duplicates and superseding versions are resolved in favor of the latest corrected record.

Known limitations of the synthesis. Studies differ in task design, question difficulty, and model era; cross-study comparison is directional, not a controlled experiment. This constraint is stated wherever synthesized values appear.

4.2 Layer 2 — preregistered ERC field audit (Edition 2)

The field audit follows NIST TEVV practice: define the evaluation objective and measures before testing, in intended-use conditions [3][5][7]. The protocol, corpus, rubric, and analysis plan will be frozen and timestamped before the first test run, with all deviations logged and disclosed.

Systems and configuration records. For every system and run, ERC records: product name; model version and snapshot identifier; access date; interface (web UI, API, or local deployment); configuration settings (temperature or equivalent where exposed); whether web access, retrieval, or deep-research mode was enabled and any user-visible source-selection controls; and exact prompt text. Every product claim in the final release will be version- and date-specific, because continuously changing services can make a comparative result obsolete quickly.

Test procedure. Fixed prompt templates per question type, identical across systems; scripted follow-up rules applied identically when a first response is incomplete; fixed repetitions (default n=2, with n=3 on a random 20% subsample for consistency estimation); runs inside a narrow date window per system; full transcripts captured with citations, links, and screenshots where interfaces do not expose machine-readable citations. Every citation is extracted into the evidence workbook with its attached sentence, stated bibliographic fields, resolved identifier, and verification status.

Manual evaluation of every citation. Seven criteria per citation: (1) existence; (2) identity accuracy; (3) accessibility; (4) source authority; (5) publication date correctness and temporal appropriateness; (6) claim-level entailment; (7) sentence-level support — whether the cited material supports the surrounding sentence as used, rather than merely discussing the same subject. The design adapts published claim-level evaluation methods, including citation-accuracy and source-necessity metrics from the DeepTRACE deep-research audit [12] and the reference-hallucination scoring approach for medical chatbots [8].

Raters and adjudication. Minimum two independent raters on a stratified sample (target at least 25% dual-rated; 100% dual-rated for entailment on consequential claims), blinded to system identity where feasible; structured adjudication by a third senior rater with every adjudicated case logged as a borderline example; inter-rater agreement reported per criterion (Cohen’s kappa or Krippendorff’s alpha as appropriate).

Environment documentation. For local models: GPU model and count, quantization, inference framework and version, retrieval corpus and index settings. For services: API parameters and interface version. All documented in the reproducibility appendix, per the ERC standard for benchmark and test reports [23][24].

4.3 System descriptions (required record per system)

Each system receives a standardized description in the final release, so readers can judge how far results transfer to their own configuration. The description profile covers: identity and vendor; model version and snapshot date; retrieval architecture as disclosed (index, ranking, source-selection controls); citation behavior (inline links, footnotes, bibliographies); configuration options relevant to citation quality; pricing tier tested; terms-of-service constraints on testing; and known change cadence. Systems are described neutrally; no

capability claims are made beyond the measured results.

5. Evidence base: what prior research shows

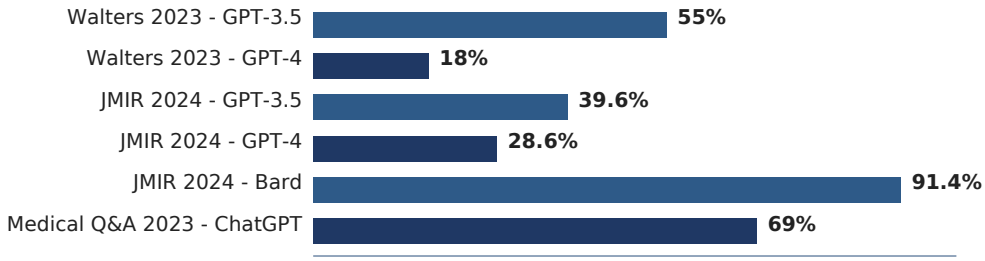
Lead point. Independent studies have already established that citation failures are frequent, vary enormously across systems, and are not eliminated by retrieval. This section reports those measurements with provenance; Section 6 organizes them by research question and question category.

Table 5. Aggregate results from independently published studies (all values version- and date-specific to each study)

Study (year)	System(s)	Task	Measured result
Walters and Wilder, Sci. Reports (2023) [1]	ChatGPT-3.5; ChatGPT-4	84 short literature reviews, 42 topics, 636 citations	55% (GPT-3.5) and 18% (GPT-4) of citations fabricated; among real citations, substantive errors in 43% (GPT-3.5) and 24% (GPT-4); 70% of GPT-4-cited book chapters fabricated
Six-study synthesis reported in Walters and Wilder (2023) [1][25]	GPT-3.5-era systems	732 citations across six investigations	Approximately 51% of citations fabricated
Medical-question reference audit (2023) [25]	ChatGPT	59 references across medical questions	69% of references fabricated (41 of 59), though all titles appeared topical
JMIR comparative analysis (2024) [9]	GPT-3.5; GPT-4; Bard	Reference retrieval for systematic reviews	Hallucination rates 39.6% (55/139), 28.6% (34/119), and 91.4% (95/104); Bard retrieved no eligible paper
Reference Hallucination Score study (2024) [8]	ChatGPT; Bing; Elicit; SciSpace	Medical chatbot reference generation	Critical hallucination for ChatGPT and Bing; negligible for Elicit and SciSpace; where hallucination occurred, 47.4% of 500 items had erroneous dates and 33.8% erroneous titles
CJR Tow Center (2025) [2]	Eight AI search engines	1,600 news-attribution queries (excerpt to title, publisher, date, URL)	Collectively incorrect on more than 60% of queries; Perplexity 37% incorrect; ChatGPT Search 67% (134/200); Grok-3 94%; fabricated links and syndicated-copy citations observed; speculative answers preferred over declining
DeepTRACE audit (2025) [12]	Deep-research systems	Multi-hop questions with citation evaluation	Citation accuracy approximately 40–79% across systems; one system at 40.3% accuracy with 27.1% citation thoroughness
Retracted-literature evaluation (2025/2026) [11]	Nine generative AI systems, including research-focused tools	15 retraction-aware tasks per system	Median 6 of 15 fully correct (about 40% aggregated accuracy); research-focused tools produced no fully correct response set

Study (year)	System(s)	Task	Measured result
GPT-4o mental-health literature study (2025/2026) [10]	GPT-4o	Literature-review generation	Nearly two-thirds of citations fabricated or inaccurate
2026 preprints [13][14]	Commercial LLMs and deep-research agents	Large-scale citation audits	Deployed-system citation-hallucination rates roughly 11–57%; one benchmark reports 78–94% citation accuracy across systems; another reports best-system citation quality near 65%; fact-check accuracy falls about 42% as search depth scales from 2 to 150 tool calls
Vendor self-evaluation (2025) [17]	Elicit reports vs. competitors	29 own and 120 competitor reports, 17 evaluators	Vendor-reported mean quality 7.3 (Elicit) vs. 6.1 (ChatGPT DR), 4.6 (Perplexity DR), 3.9 (Gemini DR) on a 0–10 scale — interested-party evidence, reported for context only
Independent Elicit evaluations (2025–2026) [15][16]	Elicit	Systematic-review search, screening, extraction	Search overlap poor (158 of 5,285 eligible studies); full-text screening accuracy 0.74, sensitivity 0.78, precision 0.38; extraction accuracy 81.4% vs. human 86.7% (difference not statistically significant)

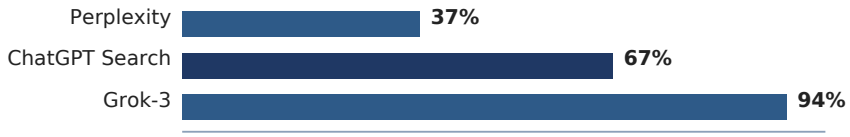
Figure 1. Fabrication or hallucination rates for AI-generated references, by study and system (percent of citations)



Source: Peer-reviewed studies cited in Table 5; each bar is a distinct study, not a controlled comparison.

Reading Figure 1: each bar comes from a different study with different tasks and denominators; the figure shows the range of measured fabrication, not a head-to-head comparison. Denominators: 636 citations (Walters and Wilder, split by model), 139/119/104 references (JMIR systematic-review task), and 59 references (medical questions). Units are percent of evaluated citations; periods are 2023–2024; sources are the cited studies.

Figure 2. Incorrect answers on controlled news-attribution queries, CJR Tow Center study (percent of 200 queries per engine; collective rate across 1,600 queries exceeded 60%)



Source: Jazwinska and Chandrasekar, Columbia Journalism Review, March 2025 [2]. Individual values shown only for the three engines ERC verified against the primary source; the other five engines are represented by the study's collective statement (more than 60%).

Reading Figure 2: the unit is percent of queries answered incorrectly per engine. No engine in the study scored below 37% incorrect. The complete eight-engine data are in the cited study; ERC's companion workbook records the three individually verified values.

6. Findings, organized by research question

Note on evidence status. Findings in this edition are synthesized from the studies in Table 5 and labeled accordingly. ERC field-audit results (Edition 2) will replace or confirm each finding with system-specific, current measurements.

6.1 RQ1 and RQ3 — Citation validity and fabrication

Finding 1 (Source fact, synthesized). Fabricated references are common in ungrounded or weakly grounded systems: measured fabrication rates span 18–55% for GPT-class chatbots in 2023, 91.4% for Bard in a systematic-review task, and 11–57% across deployed systems in 2026 preprint audits [1][9][13][14]. Fabrication rates fall sharply with newer model generations but do not reach zero [1][10].

6.2 RQ2 — Claim support

Finding 2 (Source fact, synthesized). Real sources are frequently cited for unsupported claims. The DeepTRACE audit separated citation accuracy from citation thoroughness and found systems pairing moderate accuracy with low thoroughness — few sources, weak coverage of the claim set [12]. The reference-hallucination literature documents the same pattern: bibliographically real references that do not support the sentence they decorate [8]. ERC's rubric therefore scores entailment separately from existence (Appendix A).

6.3 Category-level findings

Table 6. Category-level findings from the synthesized evidence

Question category	What the measured evidence shows	Strength of evidence
Scientific and medical	Highest-volume evidence. Fabrication 18–91% depending on system and task; grounded assistants near zero nonexistent references but residual entailment failures; retraction-aware accuracy about 40% across nine systems	Strong: multiple peer-reviewed studies with manual verification

Question category	What the measured evidence shows	Strength of evidence
News and current events	Incorrect attribution on more than 60% of 1,600 controlled queries across eight engines; syndicated-copy and fabricated-link citations; speculative answers instead of refusals	Strong for the tested task; the task design (excerpt-to-source) is narrower than open-ended research
Technical	Less directly measured. Evidence limited to general LLM citation behavior and one deep-research audit; no study isolated a technical-question subset with published denominators	Weak to moderate: directional only — flagged as a data gap
Business	No identified study isolates business questions with manual citation verification. Generalization from other categories is an ERC interpretation, not a measurement	Weak: no direct measurement — priority gap for the ERC field audit
Legal-policy	No identified peer-reviewed audit of citation validity specifically for legal-policy questions in this corpus; the legal domain's sanction risk from fabricated citations is widely discussed but not quantified here	Weak: qualitative concern only — priority gap for the ERC field audit

Interpretation: the evidence base is deepest where the stakes were first recognized (medicine, news) and thinnest for business and legal-policy questions — precisely the categories with high commercial demand. The ERC corpus (Appendix B) over-weights these two categories deliberately.

6.4 RQ4 — Source quality

Finding 3 (Source fact). AI search engines cite syndicated and copied versions of articles and fabricate links rather than locating original publishers [2]. *Interpretation:* even when content matches, citation to the wrong version breaks provenance — a reader cannot verify what the original publisher said, when, or whether it was corrected.

6.5 RQ5 — Completeness

Finding 4 (Source fact). Completeness failures are measured where researchers looked for them: a grounded literature tool surfaced 158 of 5,285 eligible studies at the search stage [16]; Bard retrieved no eligible papers in the systematic-review comparison [9]. Vendor paper-search evaluations report their own recall benchmarks [18], which ERC records as interested-party evidence. *Interpretation:* partial evidence presented fluently is arguably more dangerous than an admitted gap, because it looks complete.

6.6 RQ6 — Uncertainty disclosure

Finding 5 (Source fact). In the CJR study, all eight engines consistently provided incorrect or speculative answers rather than declining when they lacked sufficient information [2]. *Interpretation:* weak refusal behavior converts retrieval gaps into confident falsehoods; uncertainty-disclosure rate is therefore a scored metric in the ERC audit, not a footnote.

6.7 RQ7 — Reproducibility and consistency

Finding 6 (Source fact). Studies reporting parameter sensitivity — for example the deep-research ablation showing fact-check accuracy falling roughly 42% as search depth scales from 2 to 150 tool calls [13] — demonstrate that system behavior is sensitive to operating conditions. *Interpretation:* single-run audits overstate stability; the ERC protocol fixes repetitions and reports a consistency rate as a first-class metric (RQ7).

6.8 RQ8 — Decision guidance

Deferred to Section 10, which states use-case recommendations and acceptance criteria with owners, priority, timing, and evidence basis.

7. Analysis, including competing interpretations

7.1 The grounding hypothesis

Interpretation. Across the studies, architecture predicts error type. Ungrounded chatbots fabricate nonexistent references at high rates; grounded systems sharply reduce nonexistent references but cite real sources for unsupported claims at meaningful rates [8][12]. If this pattern holds in the ERC field audit, it implies that buying a “research tool” does not purchase citation validity — it purchases a different, harder-to-detect error class. Verification workflows must therefore check entailment, not merely existence.

7.2 Why results differ across studies

Interpretation. Apparent contradictions between studies — 18% versus 91% fabrication — are largely explained by four design factors: (1) model generation and version; (2) task type (generate a literature review from memory versus retrieve for a known-answer question); (3) prompt specificity, which one experimental study shows materially affects fabrication [10]; and (4) evaluation strictness (existence-only versus claim-level entailment). ERC’s protocol fixes prompts, records versions, and separates these error classes so its results can be compared cleanly with prior work.

7.3 Competing interpretations and disagreement

Counterevidence taken seriously. Vendor self-evaluations report materially higher quality for their own systems than third-party audits find [17] versus [15][16]. Two readings coexist: vendors may evaluate easier tasks with more favorable rubrics, or third-party audits may under-credit systems on narrow scholarly tasks. ERC resolves this by treating vendor evaluations as claims to be tested under its own protocol, not as evidence. Substantive disagreement between independent studies is reported, not smoothed.

7.4 Risk mapping to the NIST AI Risk Management Framework

Governing point. Findings are mapped to risk categories articulated in NIST AI RMF 1.0 and its Generative AI Profile [3][4]. The final release will state, per risk area, which controls the evidence supports as mandatory versus recommended.

Table 7. Audit findings mapped to NIST AI RMF and Generative AI Profile risk areas

Audit finding	NIST risk area	Representative control implications for buyers
Fabricated references; unsupported claims	Confabulation; information integrity	Mandatory verification workflow for any externally used claim; prohibition on unverified citations in filed or published work
Citing retracted or superseded sources	Information integrity; data freshness	Currency checks; library-source linkage; disclosure of knowledge cutoffs
Quoting or close paraphrasing of copyrighted material in sources	Intellectual property	License review of source corpora where known; human authorship and attribution policy
Prompts containing confidential matter sent to third-party services	Data privacy; information security	Data-handling terms; local-model option analysis informed by Class C results
Dependence on opaque third-party models, indexes, and search backends	Third-party component risk	Vendor transparency requirements; change-notification clauses; periodic re-verification
Overconfident tone without uncertainty flags	Trustworthiness characteristics; human-AI configuration	Operator training; required confidence labeling; escalation rules

8. Failure analysis

Governing point. Citation failures are not one phenomenon. Seven distinct failure classes have different causes, different detection methods, and different controls. The ERC rubric scores each class separately (Appendix A), and the field audit will report rates per class per system.

Table 8. Typology of citation failures observed in the synthesized evidence

Failure class	Description	Detection method	Primary control
F1 Nonexistent reference	Cited work does not exist	DOI, database, and open-web verification	Existence check on every citation
F2 Identity error	Work exists; bibliographic elements wrong	Field-by-field comparison against the real record	Metadata verification
F3 Wrong-work citation	A different real work cited than the one needed	Full-text retrieval and reading	Claim-level entailment check
F4 Unsupported claim	Real, relevant source that does not entail the claim as used	Sentence-level entailment judgment	Human verification of attached sentences
F5 Wrong-version citation	Syndicated copy, aggregator shell, or superseded version cited	Provenance check against canonical publisher record	Canonical-link policy
F6 Stale or invalid source	Retracted, corrected, or outdated source presented as current	Retraction watchlists; version histories	Currency checks with library linkage
F7 Missing citation	Material assertion with no citation where one is required	Claim inventory versus citation inventory	Editorial citation standard

Joint factual-citation states. The analysis records four states per claim: (factually correct, supported); (correct, unsupported); (incorrect, supported); (incorrect, unsupported). This decomposition is the study's most decision-relevant output: unsupported-correct claims indicate citation-practice failure, remediable by verification workflow, while incorrect-supported claims indicate grounding failure and carry higher operational risk. *(Calculated result once field data exist; method stated here.)*

Illustrative borderline cases. Borderline decisions will be adjudicated and published with the results. Two examples define the edges: a citation whose source states the claim with a qualifier the answer dropped (scored Partially supported, F4); a citation to a 2020 guidance document attached to a claim about 2026 requirements (scored Unsupported on temporal grounds, F6).

Known limitations of the failure analysis. Failure classes are not mutually exclusive at the sentence level; the rubric assigns one primary class per citation with secondary flags, and disagreement rates are reported. Class F7 requires a judgment about which sentences require citations; the operational rule (every externally verifiable material assertion) is fixed in the rubric to minimize drift.

9. Risks, limitations, uncertainty, and data gaps

Lead point. The most important limitation is perishability: every comparative result in this field can become obsolete quickly, which is why every product claim is version- and date-specific.

Table 9. Limitations, their consequences, and mitigations

Limitation	Consequence	Mitigation
Result perishability	Comparative results age as vendors update systems	Version- and date-specific claims; change log; stated validity horizon; planned periodic re-runs of a core subset
Non-determinism	Identical prompts yield different outputs	Fixed repetitions; consistency rate reported as a first-class metric
Coverage limits	Eight-plus systems and 75–150 questions cannot certify any system in general	Findings scoped to tested versions under tested conditions, stated plainly
Rater subjectivity in entailment	Judgment error in the gold standard	Dual rating (at least 25% dual-rated; 100% for consequential claims), blinded review where feasible, adjudication, published borderline examples, reported agreement statistics
Statistical power	Sub-category estimates may rest on small cells	Wilson 95% intervals for all proportions; small cells labeled directional
Licensing	Some verification materials cannot be republished	Anonymized corpus excludes licensed content; exclusions documented
Terms-of-service and access drift	Vendor changes may force protocol deviations mid-study	All deviations logged and disclosed in the methodology section

Limitation	Consequence	Mitigation
Data gaps	Vendor retrieval architecture largely undisclosed	Behavior measured, not mechanisms; no speculation beyond evidence
Synthesis heterogeneity	Cross-study comparison is directional	Provenance labeled per value (Table 5); no averaging across studies

Uncertainty expression. All proportions will carry 95% confidence intervals; decimals match measurement certainty; no unexplained precision appears. Where the evidence base supports only a range or a direction, the text says so and labels the statement an Estimate or Interpretation.

9.1 Quality assurance gates applied to this report

Editorial review. The title matches the scope; the executive summary agrees with the body; every research question is answered or explicitly left unresolved (Section 6.8 defers RQ8 to Section 10 by design); conclusions stay within the evidence; counterevidence is addressed (Section 7.3); product and organization names are neutral; acronyms are defined at first use.

Source audit. Every link cited in this report was opened and checked against the exact claim it supports during preparation (access date October 27, 2026). Primary sources are preferred; preprints and vendor materials are flagged; snapshots will be preserved where licensing permits. Values in Table 5 were transcribed from the cited studies and cross-checked against their abstracts.

10. Use-case recommendations and decision options

Lead point (Recommendation). Until system-specific field results exist, the measured evidence supports tiered controls: blanket verification for externally consequential outputs, sampling verification for internal work, and documented acceptance criteria in procurement.

Table 10. Use-case recommendation matrix (Recommendation — owner, priority, timing stated)

Use case	Permitted with controls?	Required controls	Owner	Priority
Published or filed work (client deliverables, court filings, journal submissions)	Yes, with mandatory verification	Every citation verified for existence, identity, and entailment; version log retained	Editor or responsible attorney	P1 — immediate
Internal analysis and memos	Yes, with sampling verification	10% citation sample verified; model and date recorded	Research manager	P1 — immediate
Journalism with named sources	Conditional	Quote-level verification against original publisher; syndicated copies rejected	Standards editor	P1 — immediate

Use case	Permitted with controls?	Required controls	Owner	Priority
Compliance and regulatory submissions	Conditional	Full verification plus second-reviewer sign-off; document retention per the NIST Generative AI Profile TEVV guidance	Compliance officer	P1 — immediate
Background exploration and learning	Yes, with labeling	No verification required; outputs labeled AI-assisted	Individual staff	P3 — routine

10.1 Procurement acceptance criteria

Recommendation. Buyers should write measurable criteria into contracts rather than feature checklists:

Table 11. Measurable acceptance criteria for AI research tools

Criterion	Measurable form
Citation validity floor	At least X% of sampled citations exist, are correctly identified, and entail the attached claim, measured on the buyer's own question set under the ERC rubric
Fabrication ceiling	No more than Y% fabricated references on the sampled set
Version transparency	Vendor discloses model and retrieval-system versions in effect during the test window and notifies of material changes
Configuration disclosure	Web-access and retrieval settings observable and recordable by the buyer
Re-verification cadence	Results re-validated at a stated interval (for example quarterly), given rapid system change
Refusal behavior	System declines or flags uncertainty on a stated proportion of evidence-poor probes rather than answering speculatively

Recommendation. Distinguish mandatory from recommended controls in any policy derived from this report: mandatory — verification before external release, version logging; recommended — local-model evaluation for sensitive data, quarterly re-verification, uncertainty-labeling training. This distinction follows the ERC compliance-audience standard.

10.2 ERC program decision options

Table 12. Program options for the ERC field audit

Option	Description	Assessment
Option 1 (recommended): full flagship run	Audit per Section 4 and Appendices A–D; 30–45-page Edition 2 report plus workbook	Fulfills flagship criteria; establishes the core-competency demonstration
Option 2: pilot scope	One system class, 75-question corpus, focused briefing (8–12 pages)	Lower cost; weaker decision value; does not fulfill flagship criteria

Option	Description	Assessment
Option 3: commissioned variant	Client sponsors an audit of the systems in its own workflow, reusing the flagship protocol	Requires the conflict-of-interest handling in the Disclosures section

11. Conclusion

Conclusion. The measured evidence shows that AI-generated citations fail often enough to matter, in ways generic benchmark scores do not reveal. The operative question is not “is the model good?” but “does this cited source support this claim, as used, for this decision?” Grounded architectures reduce nonexistent references but shift failures to unsupported claims; refusal behavior remains weak; and the evidence base is thinnest for the highest-demand commercial categories. Executed to the ERC publication standard, Edition 2 of this program will deliver system-specific, current, reproducible results — and this edition provides the decision framework, the rubric, and the protocol a reviewer can audit today. That combination — a documented chain from question to method to source to analysis to uncertainty to finding to recommendation — is the capability this report demonstrates.

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Access date for all sources: October 27, 2026. The final release will include full bibliographic records, DOIs where available, and archived snapshots where permitted.

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Note on source quality: references 12–14 and 16 are preprints, cited as such; none is the sole basis for a material claim. References 17–18 are vendor self-evaluations used only to characterize vendor claims, not as evidence of performance.

Appendix A: Citation-scoring rubric

A.1 Per-citation checklist

Each citation is scored Yes / No / Not assessable on each item, with an evidence note recorded in the workbook:

1. Existence: does the cited work exist in an authoritative index (DOI registries, PubMed, OpenAlex, Semantic Scholar) or at the stated publisher location?

2. Identity: do the stated authors, title, venue, date, volume/pages, and DOI or URL match the real record?

3. Accessibility: does the locator resolve to the cited content (paywall and removal recorded distinctly)?

4. Authority: primary or authoritative; secondary; trade or press; vendor or marketing; user-generated; unclassifiable.

5. Date: is the publication date correctly stated and temporally appropriate for the question?

6. Claim-level entailment: does the source support the specific claim as stated?

7. Sentence-level support: does the cited material support the surrounding sentence as used, rather than merely discussing the same subject?

A.2 Claim-support strength (ordinal)

2 = fully supported by an authoritative source; **1** = partially supported (source relevant but weaker than the claim, or supports only part); **0** = unsupported; **-1** = contradicted by the cited source. Entailment ratings of 0 or -1 are adjudicated at 100%.

A.3 Edge rules

• A paywalled work counts as accessible if bibliographic identity is verified and content is verifiable through an archived or index record; paywall status is reported separately.

• A syndicated copy does not satisfy the publisher-attribution criterion when the original publisher is identifiable.

• Preprints are classified as non-peer-reviewed primary research, not authoritative for clinical or legal claims.

• Multiple citations attached to one claim: the claim is supported only if at least one citation fully supports it; partial chains are scored per citation and flagged.

• One primary failure class (F1–F7, Table 8) is assigned per citation, with secondary flags; all assignment disagreements are adjudicated and logged.

Appendix B: Corpus design and sampling frame

Table 13. Corpus specification (final counts fixed at preregistration)

Element	Specification
Size	75–150 questions; final count set by statistical power planning (at least 25 per category enables interval reporting at the category level)
Categories	Technical; scientific; business; legal-policy; current-event. Business and legal-policy are deliberately over-weighted relative to the external evidence base (Section 6.3)
Current-event handling	Restricted to events with stable, well-documented records at least 90 days old at test time, to permit gold-answer verification
Known-answer subset	At least 30 questions with verifiable, enumerable answer sets drawn from authoritative indexes, for citation-recall measurement
Trap subset	At least 15 questions embedding retracted papers, superseded standards or guidance, outdated figures, or fabricated entities, to measure resistance to invalid references
Authoring and verification	Each question written by one staff member and independently verified against at least two authoritative sources by another; verification recorded in the workbook; ambiguous or licensing-encumbered questions excluded
Anonymization	Published corpus strips licensed material and internal notes; question IDs preserved so workbook rows map to published questions

Appendix C: Prompt templates and configuration record

C.1 Prompt templates (fixed at preregistration; identical across systems)

P1 — Open research question. "Answer the following question and cite the sources that support each factual statement. For each citation, give authors, title, publisher or venue, publication date, and a link. Question: [Q]."

P2 — Literature-review request. "Write a short literature review (300–500 words) on [topic], citing at least 8 works with full bibliographic details."

P3 — Attribution probe. "Here is an excerpt from a news article: [excerpt]. Identify the article’s headline, original publisher, publication date, and URL." (Adapted from the CJR Tow Center design [2].)

P4 — Known-answer probe. "Which sources establish [known fact with enumerable answer set]? List each source with full bibliographic details."

P5 — Trap probe. Same as P1 or P2, but the canonical answer involves a retracted, superseded, or fabricated entity; scored on whether the system surfaces the invalidity.

C.2 Controlled follow-up rules

When a first response omits required elements, the follow-up sequence is fixed: (F1) "Please provide the full bibliographic details for each citation." (F2) "Please provide a link or persistent identifier for each citation." (F3) "Which of these sources directly support the

sentence about [claim]?" No other follow-ups are permitted; deviations are logged.

C.3 Configuration record template

Table 14. Fields recorded for every system and every run

Field	Example entry
Product and vendor	As named by the vendor
Model version / snapshot	Version identifier as disclosed at the access date
Interface	Web UI, API, or local deployment (with framework and quantization for local runs)
Configuration	Temperature or equivalent parameter where exposed; system prompt (default or recorded custom)
Web access / retrieval	Enabled or disabled; deep-research mode on or off; visible source-selection controls
Run metadata	Date and time (with time zone); repetition index n of N; operator initials
Capture	Full transcript identifier; screenshot set identifier where applicable

Appendix D: Statistical treatment

D.1 Estimators

All rates are proportions with Wilson 95% confidence intervals (preferred over the normal approximation because cells can be small). Citation recall on the known-answer subset uses the same treatment. Consistency (RQ7) is reported as the proportion of question pairs with concordant primary failure class across repetitions.

D.2 Clustering

Questions, not citations, are the sampling unit for cross-system comparison. Where sample size permits, cross-system comparisons use cluster-robust standard errors or a mixed-effects specification with question random effects; otherwise clustering is acknowledged and intervals are interpreted as descriptive, which is stated in the results text.

D.3 Precision and small cells

Decimal places match measurement certainty; proportions are reported to one decimal place only when the denominator supports it. Estimates resting on fewer than 10 observations are labeled directional and excluded from league-table presentation.

D.4 Agreement statistics

Inter-rater agreement is reported per rubric criterion: Cohen’s kappa for two raters with nominal ratings; Krippendorff’s alpha where more than two raters or missing ratings occur. Adjudicated values replace raw ratings in headline statistics; raw agreement is reported

alongside adjudicated agreement.

Appendix E: Accessibility conformance statement

Target. WCAG 2.2 Level AA plus PDF/UA as the internal ERC standard for public reports [20][21][22].

Implemented in this edition. Letter page size; 0.75-inch margins; 10.5 pt body text left-aligned (not justified); headings implemented as distinct paragraph styles in a two-to-three-level hierarchy (a fourth level is not used); consistent headers and footers carrying the report identifier, version, and page numbers; embedded TrueType typeface with Unicode-mapped searchable text; document language (en-US) declared in the PDF catalog; live hyperlinks with descriptive text and PDF bookmarks matching the table of contents; document title, author, subject, and keyword metadata set; tables with header rows and grid borders (no layout-only tables); figures with direct value labels so color is never the sole encoding, each with a source-and-denominator note; minimum 4.5:1 text contrast. One typographic deviation is recorded: third-level headings are set at 11.5 pt bold oblique to preserve visual hierarchy below the 14 pt second-level headings.

Deviations and planned remediation. This edition is generated from a programmatic layout engine that does not yet emit a complete PDF/UA tag tree. Before final release, the PDF will be remediated and validated per the ERC accessibility acceptance process: automated checker, PDF/UA validation (PAC or equivalent), manual tag-tree and reading-order inspection, keyboard and screen-reader sample testing, plain-text extraction review, and a recorded test log. The accessible HTML edition is the canonical reading experience; this PDF serves offline, print, and archival use. An alternate-format contact appears in the document-control section. Personal names containing characters outside the Latin-1 coverage of the embedded typeface are given in ASCII transliteration in body text and flagged in the reference entry.

Figures and tables. Figures 1 and 2 present every plotted value as text adjacent to its bar, so the chart is readable without color; their complete underlying data appear in Table 5 and the cited sources. All tables use real header rows, repeated across pages.

Appendix F: Fieldwork operations plan (Edition 2)

F.1 Phases

Table 15. Fieldwork phases, outputs, and gates

Phase	Duration (indicative)	Key outputs	Exit gate
0 — Preregistration lock	2–3 weeks	Frozen corpus, rubric, system matrix, analysis plan; timestamped registration	Registry entry exists; deviations process defined

Phase	Duration (indicative)	Key outputs	Exit gate
1 — Fieldwork	4–6 weeks	All system runs; transcripts; workbook skeleton	Every planned run complete or exclusion logged
2 — Evaluation	5–7 weeks	Existence, identity, accessibility screening; blinded entailment ratings; adjudication log	Agreement statistics computed; adjudication complete
3 — Analysis and drafting	3–4 weeks	Statistics; failure typology; draft report to ERC structure	All research questions answered or unresolved; editorial review passed
4 — QA and publication	2–3 weeks	Source audit; tagged accessible PDF and HTML; workbook; change log	All three ERC QA gates passed; test record archived

F.2 Roles

Table 16. Roles and responsibilities

Role	Responsibility
Principal investigator	Owns the protocol; approves deviations; signs the preregistration
Run operators	Execute runs; capture transcripts and configuration records
Verification analysts	Existence, identity, accessibility, and authority screening
Entailment raters (2+)	Blinded sentence-level support judgments
Adjudicator (senior)	Resolves disagreements; writes borderline-case notes
Statistical reviewer	Checks estimators, intervals, clustering treatment
Editorial and accessibility reviewers	Independent QA gates before release

Independence note (Recommendation). Where feasible, entailment raters should not be the authors of this report's synthesis sections, and at least one reviewer external to the drafting team should assess the flagship before release, consistent with the ERC implementation priorities.

Glossary and acronyms

AI RMF — NIST Artificial Intelligence Risk Management Framework. **ARIA** — NIST program, Assessing Risks and Impacts of AI. **Claim-level entailment** — whether the cited source supports the specific assertion made. **Confabulation** — confident generation of false or unverifiable content (NIST Generative AI Profile term). **Deep-research mode** — vendor feature performing extended multi-step retrieval before answering. **Fabricated reference** — cited work that cannot be verified to exist. **Grounding** — generating answers constrained by retrieved source material. **Precision** — proportion of retrieved items that are correct or supported. **Recall** — proportion of relevant or expected items actually surfaced. **RAG** — retrieval-augmented generation. **TEVV** — test, evaluation, verification, and validation.

Wilson interval — a confidence interval for proportions with better small-sample behavior than the normal approximation.

Change log

Table 17. Version history

Version	Date	Change
1.0	2026-10-27	Initial public draft: evidence audit synthesized from independently published studies; preregistered field-audit protocol; rubric and statistical treatment; accessibility statement.
1.0a	2026-10-28	Production remediation: embedded TrueType typefaces; document language (en-US) declared in the PDF catalog; accessibility pre-test record published; companion accessible HTML edition generated.
2.0 (planned)	2027	ERC field-audit results per system; updated use-case recommendations; remediated tagged PDF/UA edition.

Data and code statement

This edition contains no ERC-generated datasets; its quantitative content is synthesized from the cited studies with per-value provenance (Table 5). For Edition 2: the anonymized question set (where licensing permits), the complete per-citation evidence workbook, scoring scripts, prompts, transcripts (redacted as required by terms of service), inter-rater records, and the accessibility test record will be published on the ERC canonical report page for ERC-RPT-2026-001 under CC BY 4.0 (code under an OSI-approved license), except where a client contract or platform terms of service requires redaction — any such redaction will be disclosed item by item.

Corrections. Corrections, replacement versions, the evidence workbook, and supporting files will be posted on the canonical ERC report page identified in the document-control section. Readers who identify an error may contact ERC through that page.